

Japan, *February 2027*

Three weeks across Tokyo, the mountains, Kyoto's old streets, and a snow week in Nozawa. Nine of us, three generations, one big birthday.

DATES	NIGHTS	OF US
2 — 25 Feb	23	9

The crew

Dad The 70-year-old	Mum	Gray
Sophie	Jess	Ben
Florence 9	Juniper 6	Goldie 2

The shape of the trip

LEG 01 · 4 NIGHTS

Tokyo

Tue 2 — Sat 6 Feb

Land late, ease in. A buffer for jetlag, body clocks, and the toddler. Big-city anchor experiences before we head into the mountains.

- Tue 2 **TRAVEL** Brisbane → Tokyo Narita, lands **17:30**. Transfer to hotel (~90 min). Conbini / hotel dinner — likely settled by 21:00.
- Wed 3 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Kappabashi-dori** kitchen town (knives, ceramics, plastic food samples). Afternoon: **Setsubun at Sensō-ji** — bean-throwing festival, oni costumes.
- Thu 4 **ANCHOR** Morning: **Tsukiji Outer Market** — sashimi breakfast, market wander. Afternoon: **Hama-rikyu Gardens** + tea house on the pond island.
- Fri 5 **ANCHOR** **Sumo morning practice** (6:30am, adult split-cohort, Ryōgoku). Afternoon: depachika browse (Mitsukoshi / Isetan). Early night before Hakone.

LEG 02 · 2 NIGHTS

Hakone

Sat 6 — Mon 8 Feb

Onsen town. Mt Fuji views, volcanic valleys, and the slow-down day before Kyoto.

- Sat 6 **TRAVEL** Tokyo → Hakone on Odakyu Romancecar (~85 min). Lunch in Yumoto. Afternoon: **Hakone Open-Air Museum**. Check in to ryokan, onsen + kaiseki dinner.
- Sun 7 **ANCHOR** **The Hakone Loop** — Tozan switchback railway → cable car → ropeway over Owakudani (volcanic valley, black eggs) → pirate ship across Lake Ashi (Fuji views) → Hakone Shrine (torii in the water) → bus back.

The cultural heart and the depth leg. Eight nights to slow right down — temples, machiya streets, sake breweries, master craft. Wide day-trip range: Himeji, Nara, Fushimi sake, Yamazaki distillery, Osaka half-day, Kaiyukan aquarium.

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| Mon 8 | TRAVEL | Hakone → Kyoto via shinkansen (~2 hr 15). Check in. |
| Tue 9 | ANCHOR | Higashiyama / Gion day — Kiyomizu-dera, Sannenzaka/Ninenzaka, Yasaka Shrine, Gion wander. Optional free walking tour in the morning. |
| Wed 10 | ANCHOR | Fushimi day — Inari shrine 1000 torii morning, Fushimi sake district afternoon (Gekkeikan museum + tasting, Kizakura). |
| Thu 11 | ANCHOR | Morning: Nara half-day — Tōdai-ji giant Buddha + deer park. Afternoon back in Kyoto. |
| Fri 12 | ANCHOR | Himeji Castle day trip (~50 min shinkansen). Keep climb + Koko-en gardens. Split-cohort if Goldie skips the keep. |
| Sat 13 | ANCHOR | Kids day — Toei Kyoto Studio Park (samurai film set, ninja shows, costume dress-up) + Kyoto Railway Museum. |
| Sun 14 | ANCHOR | Yamazaki + Kaiyukan day — split cohort, adults distillery / kids aquarium. |
| Mon 15 | FREE | Morning: forward bags to Nozawa via Yamato Takkyubin (arrives Tue). Afternoon: free / last Kyoto wander. |

LEG 04 · 5 NIGHTS — LOCKED

Nozawa Onsen

Tue 16 — Sun 21 Feb

The snow week. Skiing for those who want it, 13 free public bathhouses, and Sparena for the lower-pressure mixed-bathing option. Nozawa Dream Central is the target accommodation.

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| Tue 16 | TRAVEL | Kyoto → Tokyo → Iiyama → Nozawa (~5 hr door-to-door). Daypacks only — bags arrive separately. 9am Kyoto → ~2:30pm Nozawa . Check in, onsen, settle. |
| Wed 17 | ANCHOR | Ski day 1. Girls in lessons. Non-skiers: village + Sparena + Sakaya Honten sake. |
| Thu 18 | ANCHOR | Ski day 2. Non-skiers optional Nagano + Obuse day-trip (Zenkō-ji, Hokusai Museum, Masuichi-Ichimura sake). |
| Fri 19 | ANCHOR | Ski day 3. Non-skiers: village + onsen + relaxed pace. |
| Sat 20 | FREE | Chill day. Onsen, Sparena, slow village wander, pack. Everyone wind-down. |

LEG 05 · 4 NIGHTS

Tokyo

Sun 21 — Thu 25 Feb

Back to the city for the wind-down. The sushi-counter dinner. The last surprise. The slow re-pack.

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| Sun 21 | TRAVEL | Nozawa → Tokyo (~2.5–3 hr door-to-door). 9am Nozawa → ~12:30pm Tokyo. Daypacks only — bags forwarded Sat. |
| Mon 22 | ANCHOR | Dad's golf day — Ginza morning (Honma + Mizuno flagships), Kanda Ogawamachi afternoon (Victoria Golf + sports street browse). |
| Tue 23 | ANCHOR | Morning: Ghibli Museum (Mitaka — book tickets 10am JST on 10 Jan 2027). Evening: Dad's birthday dinner — sushi counter. |
| Wed 24 | ANCHOR | teamLab Planets (Toyosu — barefoot water immersive) + Small Worlds Tokyo (Ariake — model city park, get inserted as figurines). |

● Travel day ● Anchor day ● Free day

For Dad

the headline experiences, open for discussion

Setsubun at Sensō-ji — Wed 3 Feb

Bean-throwing festival to drive out demons. Falls on day 2 — the calendar gift of the trip.

Suntory Yamazaki Distillery tour + tasting flight

Master whisky craft. 12 min from Kyoto on the JR line. Books out months ahead.

An omakase sushi counter on his birthday

Tokyo, second leg. Chair reserved just for him.

Fushimi sake brewery walk

Kyoto's southern sake district. Tasting flight, history, Gekkeikan museum.

Private history walk in Kyoto

Knowledgeable guide, deep cuts, things you only get with someone who knows.

Engineering / how-stuff-works visit

Railway Museum, Miraikan, or a factory tour — to be slotted.

Tsukiji dawn food walk

Sashimi for breakfast, market culture, ideally with a chef-led group.

Where we're at

LOCKED IN

Flights (Brisbane → Narita, 2 Feb 17:30)

Nozawa dates (16–21 Feb)

5-leg itinerary shape

Osaka cut — Yamazaki, Kaiyukan, Castle as Kyoto day-trips

OPEN THREADS

Nozawa Dream Central — confirm dates + breakfast

Accommodation per leg (9 of us)

Activity bookings (Yamazaki, sushi, etc.)

Share with the family group